

Kyle Schwarber, All-Star & Derby Runner-Up — The Approach Behind the First Half

dp_uc20 · uc-pos-004-schwarber-first-half-allstar-001 · v1.0.0 — Phillies position-player (pos) value stream Prepared 2026-07-14 (All-Star break) · Entity lock: batter == 656941 · Regular season only

DATA WINDOW: Career pitch log 2015-06-16 → **2026-07-12** (complete first half — 93 games appeared). CHC/WSN/BOS era via data/opponents/schwarber.parquet; PHI era via data/phillies/phils_{2022–2026}.parquet. Receipts for every table: out/dp_uc20_schwarber_first_half_*.csv (17 files + 3 figures). **Manual carry-ins (not derivable from the pitch log): 2026 All-Star selection; Home Run Derby runner-up.** If quoted after 2026-07-12, staleness must be stated.

Bottom line

Schwarber's 32-HR, .391-wOBA half is **not new strength — it is the most committed version of a trade he has been drifting toward for a decade.** Bat speed is flat year-over-year (74.2 mph), exit velocity sits inside his career band, and his swing is actually *shorter* than 2024. What changed: he swings at strikes at the highest rate of his career (.675 in-zone), converts a career-high share of contact into pulled air (.320), has nearly evicted the ground ball (27.5%, career low), and front-loads his damage before two strikes (.663 wOBA even-or-behind; 12 HR in PA that end within two pitches). The bill is a career-worst 35.3% whiff rate and 34.7% K rate — and he pays it on purpose, because the walks survived (13.5% BB, chase a manageable .252) and the runs did too: 107.4 wRC/600, third-best of his career.

1. The measurables

Bats L / throws R, age 33 (b. 1993-03-05), listed 6'0"/229 — *reference carry-ins*. What Statcast measures directly (receipts: `_battracking`, `_battedball`, `_2026_hr_log`):

Measurable	2024	2025	2026 1H
Avg bat speed (mph)	75.0	74.2	74.2
Fast-swing rate (≥75 mph)	.706	.698	.684
Swing length (ft)	7.64	7.46	7.44
Attack angle (°)	—	14.5	14.7
Avg EV (mph)	93.6	94.3	93.4
90th-pct EV	109.2	109.8	109.1
Max EV	115.6	117.2	113.2

The 32 first-half homers averaged **403.6 ft at 106.6 mph off the bat, longest 460 ft** — the raw material the Derby audience saw was on display all half. But note the direction of every row above: flat or slightly down. The engine did not get bigger.

2. The KPI panel, against his career

.254/.359/.558 (.917 OPS), wOBA .391, 32 HR in 415 PA — a 46.3 HR/600 pace, dead-even with his 56-HR 2025 (46.7), with career highs nowhere in the engine and everywhere in the outcomes mix. 2016 (5 PA, injury year) excluded from narrative.

Season	PA	HR	BA	OBP	SLG	OPS	wOBA	K%	BB%	HardHit%	Barrel%	P/ PA	HR/ 600
2015 (CHC)	273	16	.246	.352	.487	.839	.363	28.2	12.8	42.9	12.3	4.26	35.2
2017	486	30	.210	.313	.466	.778	.332	30.9	11.9	42.0	15.2	4.34	37.0
2018	491	26	.238	.328	.466	.794	.341	28.5	11.8	45.3	12.8	4.36	31.8
2019	606	38	.249	.333	.530	.864	.356	25.7	10.7	51.3	14.6	4.19	37.6
2020	223	11	.188	.305	.393	.698	.307	29.6	13.0	48.4	11.5	4.28	29.6
2021 (WSN/ BOS)	472	32	.264	.371	.551	.922	.390	26.9	13.3	52.4	17.6	4.21	40.7
2022	666	46	.218	.320	.504	.824	.355	30.0	12.5	54.5	20.1	4.32	41.4
2023	716	47	.196	.338	.473	.811	.350	29.9	16.9	48.8	16.4	4.29	39.4
2024	689	38	.247	.361	.484	.846	.365	28.6	14.8	55.5	15.6	4.14	33.1
2025	719	56	.239	.357	.561	.918	.390	27.4	14.0	59.6	20.8	4.26	46.7
2026 1H	415	32	.254	.359	.558	.917	.391	34.7	13.5	53.4	19.4	4.30	46.3

Read the last row twice: a **career-worst strikeout rate** living inside a **career-best wOBA**. That contradiction is the whole report.

3. Run creation (SC-1, new KPI this UC)

wRC from the locked wOBA and FanGraphs season constants: **74.3 runs created in 415 PA — 107.4 wRC/600**, behind only 2021 (110.3) and 2025 (108.2). At his 2026 PA pace that is a ~124-wRC full season, within range of 2025's 129.6 despite the strikeout spike. Receipt: `_wrc_by_season.csv` (2026 constants are FanGraphs in-season values — flagged provisional in the spec).

4. What did NOT change: the engine

Rule out "got stronger" first: bat speed flat (\$1), avg EV 93.4 and hard-hit 53.4% *below* 2025 (94.3 / 59.6), barrel 19.4% vs 20.8. On pure contact quality this is his 2022/2025 band, not a new tier. Same engine; different firing schedule and direction — the Marsh finding, one weight class up.

5. What changed: the approach

Indicator	2023	2024	2025	2026 1H	Career note
Swing rate	.377	.399	.418	.443	highest since 2015 rookie half
In-zone swing rate	.558	.607	.641	.675	career high
First-pitch swing rate	.233	.271	.275	.316	career high
Chase rate	.216	.209	.215	.252	worst since 2015, still moderate

Indicator	2023	2024	2025	2026 1H	Career note
Whiff rate	.315	.320	.331	.353	career worst
Zone rate seen	.470	.479	.477	.461	near career low
P/PA (SC-2)	4.29	4.14	4.26	4.30	stable — patience retained
Pulled-air rate	.259	.245	.272	.320	career high
Ground-ball rate	.346	.409	.343	.275	career low
Air rate (FB+LD)	.539	.513	.569	.628	career high
Sweet-spot rate	.354	.331	.363	.417	career high

Pitchers are throwing him *fewer* strikes than ever (.461 zone seen) and he is attacking the ones he gets harder than ever. The signature is **selective aggression, not indiscriminate aggression**: in-zone swing up 3.4 points on 2025 while P/PA held at 4.30 and the walk rate held at 13.5% — he added the A-swing without surrendering the count. Where the damage lands (receipts: `_countstate`, `_earlycount_pa`):

- **Even-or-behind counts: .663 wOBA, 14 HR** — career high by ~120 points of wOBA.
- **PA ended within two pitches: .643 wOBA, 12 HR in 74 PA** — career best (prior best .563, 2025).
- **Two-strike PA: .223 wOBA, 57.4% K** — career-worst two-strike K rate, in a career-typical two-strike wOBA band.

He has effectively **written off the two-strike PA to maximize the pre-two-strike PA**. 60.5% of his PA still reach two strikes (career-normal), but the other 39.5% now produce most of a full season's damage.

Two more splits fill in the half (receipts: `_platoon`, `_pitchgroup`):

- **vs LHP: .415 wOBA, 11 HR in 159 PA (38.3% LHP exposure)** — the best vs-left half of his PHI era, on career-high lefty volume. The 2015–21 platoon liability is fully retired.
- **By pitch group**: fastball wOBA .472 (20 HR); offspeed .421 — up 90 points on 2025; breaking balls remain the tax: .272 wOBA, 45.9% K, chase up to .292. The league's obvious counter is more spin; so far he is out-slugging the tax.

6. The narrative: tangible actions each persona could have taken

Inference consistent with the indicators — the data cannot see intent. Each claim traces to §1–§5.

Schwarber — sell out for the ball in the air, earlier. Career-high in-zone swing and first-pitch swing with a *shorter* swing and flat bat speed is a decision change, not a body change: commit the A-swing to the first hittable pitch, accept the whiff. The 27.5% ground-ball rate says the swing is now organized around one outcome — pulled air — and .320 pulled-air with 86% of grounders pulled is total commitment to the plan.

The hitting department — protect the walk while installing the aggression. The aggression Marsh installed cost him his walk rate (4.7%); Schwarber's version kept 13.5% BB because the chase moved only 3.7 points. That is the harder trick and the more repeatable profile. Their open second-half item is the same one as Marsh's: breaking-ball chase (.292) is drifting up, and a 34.7% K rate leaves no batting-average floor if the pulled-air conversion cools.

The manager — bank the lefty leverage. .415 wOBA vs LHP on career-high exposure removes the last argument for resting him against tough lefties; the platoon card now runs the other way. The 4-hole is producing 107 wRC/600 — lineup construction around him is a solved problem for the second half.

7. Candid caveats (read before extrapolating)

- **The K rate is real and career-worst** (34.7%, two-strike K 57.4%). The profile holds only while ~1 in 5 balls in play is a barrel; a two-week EV dip turns this half's .254 BA into .210 fast.
 - **wOBA .391 vs xwOBA proxy .378** — modest overrun, nothing like a red flag, but the direction is "hot," not "underpaid."
 - **July is soft:** .336 wOBA, 2 HR in 48 PA — below the 50-PA floor, directional only.
 - **2026 wOBA/wRC constants are in-season FanGraphs values** and will move by season's end; wRC figures are provisional to $\pm 2\%$.
 - **Max EV 113.2 is his lowest full-tracking top-end since 2015** — worth one look in August; a top-end EV decline at 33 would be the first true aging flag.
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Locked KPI mechanics inherited verbatim from dp_uc18 / Baseball Functions (get_stats wOBA with FanGraphs season weights; chase = swings at zone>9; hard-hit = EV $\geq$ 95 on type=='X'; barrel = launch_speed_angle==6). "xwOBA" is the locked BIP-weighted proxy (estimated_woba_using_speedangle mean), not full Statcast xwOBA. NEW KPIs this UC: SC-1 wRC (run creation), SC-2 P/PA — specs in governance 03. IBB excluded from BB per locked definitions. DQ: 24,562 deduped pitches, 0 duplicate keys, all BIP null rates $\leq 1.1\%$ — out/ dp_uc20_schwarber_first_half_dq_receipts.csv. Governance package: Agents for Data Products/data-products/uc-pos-004-schwarber-first-half-allstar-001/. Ledger: this is UC #21 / uc-pos-004 / dp_uc20 — ledger update pending.